

Lab - Social Engineering

Objectives

Research and identify social engineering attacks

Background / Scenario

Social engineering is an attack with the goal of getting a victim to enter personal or sensitive information, this type of attack can be performed by an attacker utilizing a keylogger, phishing email, or an in-person method. This lab requires the research of social engineering and the identification of ways to recognize and prevent it.

Required Resources

PC or mobile device with internet access

Instructions

Using a web browser find the article “Methods for Understanding and Reducing Social Engineering Attacks” on the SANS Institute website. A search engine should easily find the article.

The SANS Institute is a cooperative research and education organization that offers information security training and security certification. The SANS Reading Room has many articles that are relevant to the practice of cybersecurity analysis. You can join the SANS community by creating a free user account to access to the latest articles, or you can access the older articles without a user account.

Read the article or choose another article on social engineering, read it, and answer the following questions:

What are the three methods used in social engineering to gain access to information?

- Social engineering is conducted via the three key approaches: electronic access, physical access, and social media. Such processes enable malicious individuals to deceive individuals over the internet, in real life or in social media content posted on social sites.

What are three examples of social engineering attacks from the first two methods in the previous question?

- There are three typical ones, namely, phishing, tailgating, and impersonation. Phishing involves the use of counterfeit emails or web sites to personalize information. Tailgating occurs when an individual stalks an employee into an area of security. Impersonation is done where the attacker impersonates a trusted person, such as a technician or a co-worker.

Why is social networking a social engineering threat?

- Social networking is a threat since individuals tend to post personal details on the internet. This information can be used by attackers to guess passwords or can be used to produce fake messages that look like real ones and, thus, it becomes easier to fool the victims.

How can an organization defend itself from social engineering attacks?

- Organizations can protect against social engineering through training, the use of strong security policies as well as the addition of additional security features, such as multi-factor authentication. They are also expected to train the workers on how to be cautious when using the emails and to confirm about the suspicious requests.

What is the SANS Institute, which authored this article?

- SANS Institute is an organization, which offers cybersecurity training, research, and certifications. It assists individuals and organisations to know how to secure their systems and information against attacks.